Gen. Shahbeg Singh when he expected the army action to start, he replied, ‘ Maybe tonight’. [8]

The ignored SOP

Lt Gen. S.K. Sinha was GOC-in-C, Western Command, before Lt Gen. Sundarji took over. Judging from the deteriorating situation in Punjab, Lt Gen. Sinha had sensed that one day in the not-so-distant future the army might be called to flush out Sikh militants from gurudwaras, especially the Golden Temple complex. To deal with such an eventuality, he had devised a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP), which included the following steps:

i. The whole operation has to be carried out in as transparent a manner as possible in the presence of some respectable local Sikh witnesses.

ii. There should be live TV coverage.

iii. The Golden Temple complex should be duly cordoned off to prevent entry or exit of unauthorized persons till the operation was over.

iv. If the siege persisted, water and power supply should be cut off, followed by a public announcement to encourage voluntary surrender.

v. Keeping in view the sensitivity of about 80,000 Sikh soldiers, both officers and men, they should be taken into confidence and sensitized about the reasons behind the operation and the precautions being taken in carrying it out.

vi. A temporary gurudwara must be established outside the Golden Temple complex with continuous recitation of the holy scriptures.

vii. Officers and jawans involved in the operation should remove their shoes, cover their heads and offer prayers at the temporary gurudwara before entering the Golden Temple complex.

viii. The operation should be carried out under the overall command of a senior Sikh army officer with a mix of Hindu and Sikh troops. [9]